

Shadows of Titan

His cheek was wet and he swiped at it, furious with himself. This was a tactical mission, and he had found out where he needed to go next. If her files were anything like his, then her location would be in there as well. And that's all he needed.

He landed hard on his balcony, ice sloughing off his cloak in sheets as the stabilising field snapped into place. Oxygen flooded his lungs with a rush, but his knees buckled the moment he touched down. Agony lanced through his skull and down to his wings, his entire body spasming as he clawed his way inside.

The suppressors kicked in too late; the room was already screaming with feedback. He didn't even hear the door open, just the warm pressure of a Nullify-field sweep over him like a soft tide.

The soft, familiar presence of Lynx Kairen wrapped around him. Silent and steady, his hand pressed gently to Thal's back, dampening the wild flare without a question. Thal's wings were still extended across the floor, quivering violently; he couldn't retract them, couldn't move.

"I need **control**," Thal growled, fist slamming into the ground, the floor spiderwebbing where his fist connected.

Lynx didn't answer, his Nullify-field pulsing tighter around him. He needed to pull it together. He took in a deep breath, pressing the weight of everything to the back of his mind, letting the quiet man's energy work over his own. Without a word, he forced his wings back into their ports with a sickening grind of metal, energy, and sinew. He could feel Lynx's eyes scrutinising him, and he was grateful the man knew when to keep his mouth shut.

Chapter 19

Myth woke with a sharp inhale, her entire body thrumming with energy. Her skin practically glowed, her pale luminescent freckles catching in the low light of Darius's quarters. She stretched lazily beneath the blankets, a small smile stretching on her lips. The warmth beside her shifted and she rolled toward him, poking a finger against his ribs.

"Wakey, wakey, fire man," she whispered, giggling as he groaned and tried to roll away. He shifted suddenly, flipping on top of her with a sleepy growl, pinning her with his weight. She laughed louder, warmth pooling in her stomach that had nothing to do with his body temperature.

"We gotta hurry up!" she said with a few more well-timed pokes. "C'mon! Up!"

Darius groaned dramatically and let her wriggle free, watching her pad barefoot to the door with a grin. She warped back to her room and when they both emerged, they were back in

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their regulation Apex uniforms, but she couldn't help noticing how the tips of his hair still smouldered, a smoky edge that made him look unfairly hot. She felt her cheeks heat up, the surplus of energy thrumming loudly in her ears at the thought.

They had a rushed breakfast in the Apex mess hall. Nyx chewed absentmindedly while Darius ate an impressive amount of heat-melded protein bricks. Slowly, the others trickled in, groggy and in varying states of composure. Lynx, sharp as ever, silent and observing. Rhea arrived not long after, a coffee flask in one hand, nodding silently. Seren yawned as he dragged himself in, looking like he hadn't slept in days as his light fractals flickered wildly, while Eira walked coldly in after him, perfectly crisp as usual.

A few Echelon members joined them as well: Riven Drayth, who introduced himself with a cocky smile and a wink at her, earning a small glare from Darius. Apparently he was Darius's enforcer and his resemblance to him was uncanny, even though he was a shorter, more rugged version. Vaerin Lyric arrived last, silent, soft winds wrapping around her lithe form, her lilac hair gently waving in the wind as she introduced herself, her quiet presence oddly comforting.

Without much fanfare, their group was ushered into the transport bay. Nyx's nerves hummed as she boarded the transport. Darius stood beside her, his energy hot but calming. The group didn't speak much and it wasn't long before the Halo Crucible emerged into view, like a coliseum etched into the void.

Suspended in orbit above Titan, the ring-arena shimmered like a relic; carved from obsidian and laced with radiant gravity lines, it glowed and glittered in the twilight. Inside, the gravity and pressure were heavily controlled. Power suppressors were layered deep, but still allowed raw output. The audience, made up of the AAN's Upper Echelon and other Apex

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members, watched from shielded galleries above, their faces hidden behind golden masks and polished visors.

Only Darius and she stepped into the arena. The air was thin around her, the floor humming underneath her boots. She instantly noticed Darius was glowing. Not metaphorically, but actually glowing. His Magma-lined gauntlets radiated heat, his aura shifting brighter and sharper.

She rolled her shoulders as a voice cut through the arena from high above. It echoed off the walls, every word sharp and polished. “Captain Darius Valkyrie. Operative Nyx. You are hereby ordered by the High Council to display the full extent of your resonant abilities. Mutation profiling and Tier reassessment to follow.” The man in a pitch-black AAN common suit continued, his voice commanding. “Captain Valkyrie will proceed first.”

Nyx offered Darius a small smile as she stepped back toward the inner arc of the Crucible’s defence wall.

Darius strode to the centre of the Crucible with calm, lethal intent. Every step echoed with authority, the twilight from the sun reflecting against the orbital ring. His boot ignited first, flames licking up his legs in tight spirals as his gauntlets flared to life. His shoulders ignited, his plated armour flaring molten red, his hair flamed like an inferno, fire coiling from the ends like waves.

As the above galleries darkened, the arena rumbled below. She felt a shiver down her spine as the first wave dropped. They were Dreg-tier test monsters, engineered for resistance and aggression. Misshapen limbs, layered hides and armoured joints flew at him in a wave, but they never reached him. The air around Darius ignited; the weaker monsters disintegrated before they

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got within reach. Their bodies hissed and folded in on themselves, cores erupting from the thermal pressure alone.

As the stronger ones were released, he moved with terrifying speed, launching into the air, diving and spinning with lethal strikes. His gauntlets shattered bone and hide like paper, every opponent going down in one hit, executed with scientific brutality.

The Halo Crucible's ground surged, the side gates yawning open releasing hundreds of smaller mutated symbiote-tier Dregs, gnashing and crawling over each other like a swarm of black locusts.

Darius stopped moving, hovering as the ground beneath him cracked and melted. His arm raised outward slowly as a molten sphere formed in his palm, dense, swirling, and pulsing like a collapsed sun. The fiery orange turned flash-white, then a brilliant blue as his entire form erupted into cerulean fire. The molten ball expanded and grew, surging with plasma pressure, a volatile storm barely contained.

The Crucible shook as countermeasures and heat shields automatically deployed. The spectators backed away from the viewing edge as the air began to warp around him as he rose higher and higher until he hovered above the Halo Crucible's protective shields.

With a pointed finger, the cerulean inferno was unleashed into space.

The explosion tore the darkness open with a blinding nova of blue fire. A shockwave of energy and unbearable heat expanded in concentric rings, blinding her eyes.

She had to blink a few times and as her sight returned, her heart thudded irregularly. The arena floor was glass. Every Dreg creature had been fused into the scorched floor, their bodies twisted molten shadows. Steam coiled upward around the petrified remains as Darius landed in silence. He still burned brightly as his body softly transitioned from deep sapphire to gold.

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He didn't look out of breath or exhausted at all. If anything, he looked excited. His eyes shimmered, blue-orange fire tinting them, the heat around him so intense it radiated through the air. She took a deep breath and stepped forward steadily. The air felt thinner and she could feel the eyes on her. She focused herself, waiting for the buzzer.

As soon as the shrill sound rang out, a pulse rippled from her body. Her skin shifted fast, smooth obsidian fractal veins with white-hot luminescence blooming over her skin as the first wave of Dreg-tier opponents dropped into the ring.

Two barely made it forward when space fractured around them, pulling their screams and bodies inward. With a flick of her hand, she erased them mid-lunge. Their mass displaced into a deep vacuum exploding out, shattering three others. She surged again, her energy flashing bright and wide, cutting through the remaining creatures like a knife through water, all their energy, matter and rage absorbed into the dark sheen of her skin.

Then the second wave dropped. Bigger and meaner, born in some lab or subterranean abyss, these Dregs were out for blood. Her finger twitched as she reached for them, a smile on her face as time buckled around them. The arena froze as she moved smoothly through the distortions, the world around her blurring into a haze of energy and light as she pulled upward. The Crucible's gravity bent and arena fragments lifted and twisted into frozen spirals. Her after-images began to multiply, full versions of herself frozen in time, energy exploding outward, until she was everywhere.

More and more Dregs were pulled into the field as the wells of the Halo Crucible opened to release a torrential flood of bodies being ripped apart before even touching the ground. From the centre of the arena, she nullified her field, her after-images snapping back into her body, each resulting shockwave a scream of destructive light and energy. The arena screamed and

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containment fields flashed and warbled desperately as gravity warped inward. The walls began to groan as more sections folded and sheared away, electrical charges screaming as they were ripped from their ports. The night sky above them tore open in a perfect seam of burning white light slicing toward the stars and slowly expanding outward. The remaining Dregs disintegrated. No screams, they were just gone. But she couldn't stop.

The arena floor itself began to break apart far beneath her, glass and metal shearing upward into shards and spinning debris. Her hair whipped violently around her, her eyes closed, somehow at peace in the screaming chaos around her.

She opened her eyes to see chunks of the containment ring break free and spiral inward toward her, only to be caught and absorbed harmlessly in her field. Alarms screamed and she saw the Crucible begin to shift. She exhaled deeply. She focused hard, feeling time pull back in on itself. Unravelling the destruction, reversing the broken arcs of steel and titanium, reassembling each grain of sand, each wire, and every screw.

She landed gently on the newly restored arena floor, the alarms warbling off in mechanical confusion.

The silence was deafening as she walked back to Darius. She gave him a crooked smile at his shocked look and asked, "So, when do we hear the results?"

He blinked, the heat swirling around him gently. "Probably when we get back. What, you trying to upstage me?"

She laughed lightly. "Me? Never!"

He laughed loudly at that as they walked back out to the transport bay. It seemed like multiple emergency transports had been dispatched to the Halo Crucible when it started destabilising, a precautionary measure ensuring sufficient ways back onto the planet.

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Nyx and Darius split off to one craft together; the moment they settled in, an alert pulsed on the console:

**PRIORITY ALERT: CPT. VALKYRIE AND OP. NYX — REPORT TO
COMMAND CHAMBER 4C AT1800 hours..**

Darius snorted. “A request? Yeah, no. That’s a demand.”

Nyx groaned playfully. “Ugh that only gives us a couple of hours to finish that training session with the cadets and get cleaned up . Are we in trouble?”

“We?” he snorted. “Nah. I was amazing. You... eh?”

She laughed, leaning her head back against the padded wall of the transport. “You’re impossible.”

“Takes one to know one,” he shot back.

The mood stayed light as they rocketed back toward Helion Prime, the surface of Titan sprawling below like a fractured jewel. Nyx watched the clouds blur past, her skin still tingling, her mind still racing from earlier. She tried not to think too deeply about Darius’s power spike as well, but the intense heat rolling off the man made it hard to ignore.

They landed without incident and started towards the main corridors of the AAN as whispers followed them. Hasty salutes were given to Darius and stares lingered longer than usual. She tried to ignore the clear buzz in the air, but her mind screamed for her to have her guard up.

Chapter 20

Bryn Alaric didn't sit with the others. He crouched in the highest rafters of the Crucible's viewing ring, half-immersed and anchored in the shadows. People didn't normally notice him as it was, but this was a way to view everything and everyone almost completely privately.

The arena below still trembled and thrummed, heat rippling off the glass where Valkyrie had turned the material into a molten canvas. Bryn hadn't flinched away the moment Valkyrie went blue, but he had noticed the entire chamber shift. Awe, panic, whispers, calculations flitting through the air rapidly. He watched them closely. High Chancellor Mereen was scribbling furiously, sweat rolling past her jaw despite the coolness of the climate-controlled room. The man beside her, Lord Cassien from the House of King, wore a grimace, his eyes in a tight squint. Their entourage of dignitaries and ambassadors sat behind them tight-lipped.

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Bryn couldn't help but smirk. He turned his attention back to the arena just as Nyx walked forward. Even from this distance, there was something about her presence that tore at the corners of his mind. He turned his eyes from her as she transformed and focused on Commander Voxx. He was sitting forward in his seat, his wings shifting slightly with the tension fluttering through his thick frame. Bryn frowned; Commander Voxx was never this animated.

Bryn watched as Lynx was already at his side, his Nullify-field pulsing strongly, and Bryn moved deeper into the shadows. He didn't want to get caught in it and fall from the ceiling.

His eyes swept over the rest of the room taking everything in, committing it to memory. Eira was standing ramrod-stiff; Seren had a protective hand on her back, murmuring something low, but he didn't look very steady either. Dr. Vaelith looked worse, her green hand gripping her chest, eyes wide as if she were fearing for her life.

Bryn turned his eyes back to the viewing panel to see Nyx like a storm. Bryn felt a pang of jealousy. Jealous of how powerful she was, how everyone was watching her, how everyone shook in fear as the Crucible itself trembled. He retreated fully into the rafters as the light from the viewing panel started eliminating shadows and the security panels started snapping into place. He made sure to note who looked more scared as the whispers in the room rose to an audible clamour. Alarms were blaring and transports were being prepared.

Before he felt any actual structural damage, he saw as she... He couldn't describe it and almost lost his foothold in the shadows. He felt his gut twist, the noise in the room reached a crescendo, and the almost eye-bleeding pressure took over as everyone shouted to be heard. It seemed like Nyx had fixed the imminent damage, but everyone was in a hurry to get out of there and back on solid land. He moved quietly, avoiding Lynx at all costs, and entered the transport

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undetected. He sat and buckled in as everyone milled in around him, all too wrapped up in their own conversation to notice him. As usual.

He shook his head, swallowing his disgust as he discreetly pressed the embedded chip in his collarbone. His next report would have to be exact, so what everyone was saying was important. It had a short-range pulse, so it wasn't useful unless you were in a group. A group of walking weapons too wrapped up in their own little worlds to care about anyone else.

His report would be unforgiving and he would hold nothing back. Not just because he was loyal. But because he truly believed that the great age of the Apex was coming to an end. And he relished the thought.

Chapter 21

The training exercise wasn't supposed to be anything stressful, just a routine drill to keep sharp while they waited for the High Council's assessment following the almost cataclysmic display at the Halo Crucible. Darius had made sure to choose a standard exercise at the Redgate Bastion, the outer-tier facility in the Ember Crown of Forgedeep Apex. Captains and Tech Enforcement alike ran high-heat simulations with their handpicked squads after administrative duties. The Bastion itself was a fortress of ruby-infused tantalum hafnium carbide; its gates had the ability to withstand the brunt of Titan's volcanic fissures. The training arena was built with

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solar-glass panelling, volcanic rock stabilisers, and active cryo-layers built into the floor. Perfectly designed to contain insane heat and unpredictable power surges.

Darius stood at the centre, sweat pouring down his temples, neck, and back, the flickering blue flames coiling tight around his fists. The heat shimmered like a mirage around him; the sky above the Bastion darkened with the rising smoke, the atmospheric filters unable to keep up with the unstable flames.

He knew he should call off the exercise as he launched a barely controlled burst of Magma energy toward the target array. A standard flare arc meant to strike five bots in sequence. It should have been so easy he could have done it in his sleep. Instead, the flames surged, engulfing the bots, blue fire exploding outward and slamming into the range walls. A responding crack radiated through the space, the obsidian tiles snapping, the sensors wailing as they liquefied.

“Captain!” Riven Drayth’s voice cracked as he shouted, the panic in his voice unmistakable.

Darius turned, teeth clenched, watching as the cadets Vaerin Lyric and Riven Drayth tried to shield themselves with cyclone barriers and flame dampeners. But those were nowhere near enough as the temperature kept climbing, the swirling smoke making the air thick and hotter than it already was. He watched, panic rising in his chest, as Lyric dropped to one knee, coughing, her stormfield flickering weakly against the onslaught.

“Captain! You’re—you’re losing control!” she cried out, pale eyes wide and fearful.

He tried to fight the panic, tried to ground his stance, and force the energy back. His arms trembled, his skin shifting from its orange hue to a sickly bluish colour. The searing heat flooded his chest, ripping through his ribs, forcing a scream of pain out.

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Not again, not again, not again. He felt his knees hit the molten ground, the flames flaring and the smell of burnt flesh spiking the air. He could feel it happening again; he could feel himself spiralling. He gasped for air, but it was thick with ash and smoke, and the edges of his vision began to darken and blur as panic took hold in his chest.

An explosive release of blue flames rippled outward as he felt the ground buckle more, the cooling pockets giving out under the sheer heat. He felt his muscles blister as the searing pain radiated throughout his frame. He heard the alarm klaxons and the distant shouts as his team scrambled for suppressants.

And then, when he was scared he was going to fall face-forward into the molten ground, he felt a sudden wash of cool relief flood his chest. The glacial flood wove through his bloodstream, hissing as the raging inferno in him diminished.

He looked up, dazed, to see Nyx kneeling beside him, one hand on his shoulder, the other gently raised as silver energy spun through the air. Time folded in ribbons around her fingers as structures reassembled. The heat receded and the training area returned to its original state with almost a breath of relief.

His body ached and burned, the pain an unbearable throb until he felt her arms wrap around him. He let out a gasp as he felt her energy flowing into him, her forehead against his chest. “You are going to hurt yourself,” she whispered, “past what I can fix. And I don’t know what I’ll do.” Her voice cracked.

Darius lifted her face, his hands trembling. She was crying, tears flowing freely down her cheeks as her energy flooded into him. He nodded, the guilt heavy in his throat. He didn’t deserve her care, and the repercussions of her doing this for him were going to be grave.

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She helped him up, his strength flooding back through his body, her presence still wrapped around him like a tether.

“Captain Valkyrie.” Commander Voxx’s voice snapped through the air like a blade. He stood at the edge of the training wall, wings fully deployed, the six radiant extensions of energy curled around his squad like a shield. Lyric and Drayth peeked through the white feathers with wide eyes, clearly rattled but unharmed.

As Voxx retracted his wings, Darius saw the black scorch marks still fanned across the protective dome. The Commander didn’t even blink. “Report to Command. **Now**,” he ground out before turning abruptly and stalking away.

Darius let out a shaky breath he didn’t know he had been holding. This was going to be bad. He made a quick, split-second decision, purposely not fully weighing the consequences as he grabbed Nyx by the arm and quickly pulled her into the transport and back to Helion Prime. Nyx looked over at him, brow furrowed. “Is everything... going to be okay?”

He didn’t answer right away as he docked the transport, then finally turned to her. “No. Not really.”

Her mouth opened, but he gently took her wrist and pulled her along, not waiting for more questions. The hallways buzzed with murmurs, eyes trailing them as they made their way through the heavy influx of Apexes.

“I need you to understand something,” he said, pulling her closer as he walked. “That kind of energy, what you used on me, it’s rare. Healing-based resonance at that scale? It’s practically a myth...” He frowned briefly, looking down at her wide silver eyes before continuing. “I should be dead from the damage alone. And now... well.” They reached her room. He stopped and turned toward her. “If you have somewhere safe to go,” he said, his voice sharp,

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“somewhere off-grid, even for a few hours. **Go.** I’ll ping your comtech when I know what’s happening.”

Her lips parted like she wanted to argue, but he shook his head. Her eyes pierced through him and he wanted to explain more, but time was running out. “**Go,**” he said again.

She nodded finally. “Be careful,” she whispered, then she vanished in a flicker of warped air.

Darius breathed a sigh of relief as he turned back down the hallway, walking swiftly to the opening where he was met with an armed escort. Full gear and suppression-grade weapons. He rolled his eyes. “Really?” He shook his head and stalked through them. He knew where he needed to go and he left the escort to catch up. As he stormed through the increasingly opulent halls to the High Chamber, he steeled himself, the imposing ceiling etched with golden filigree of Apex victories bearing down on him. He already knew at least half the counts they’d pin him with: recklessness, insubordination, concealment of volatile Apex behaviour.

The colossal painite doors loomed large and burnished red in front of him, hissing open slowly as he approached then slamming shut behind him, sealing him inside the High Court.

The full AAN High Council was present, with High Chancellor Mereen seated at the centre of the crescent table, flanked by General Threx, Commander Voxx, Dr. Ekros, Dr. Vaelith, as well as numerous high-ranking delegates from Cryothorne, Verdant Verge, Obsidian Reach, Stratos Gate, and Helion Prime.

He saluted sharply, coming to attention on the centre dais. High Chancellor Mereen stood in a flurry of regal capes and medals. “Captain Valkyrie. You are guilty of so much, I won’t even waste my breath reading off the counts. I will deal with that later. But this selfishness, this foolish recklessness! Keeping something this important, this vital from us!” Her voice ended in a

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slight shriek. “The danger you and Operative Nyx have exposed us to is immense,” she continued, smoothing her hands over her garments. “I move to have Operative Nyx decommissioned from the Apex Corps. Immediate restriction and indefinite containment for further testing.”

Before Darius could speak, to his surprise, Commander Voxx stood. “High Chancellor, these energies are highly volatile. Abruptly stripping her of her identity, her role, and putting her in a cage, we risk not only losing what little rapport we have, but also massive, massive collateral damage.”

Dr. Vaelith stood. “I concur. Emotional destabilisation could trigger a catastrophic response we are in no way equipped to handle.”

Dr. Ekros practically barked as he jumped to his feet. “To act rashly now would jeopardise any chance we have of parsing her mutation. I recommend restricted duties, ongoing observation, and possible, gradual integration into a controlled—” His voice was drowned out as the chamber roared with rising arguments. The High Chancellor motioned furiously for silence.

A delegate from Stratos Gate leaned forward; his white face, pointed ears, and wispy colorless hair made him look almost like an apparition. “And what will you do when you have her? Clone her? Embryonic pairings? Controlled resonance trials?” His thin voice jilted with sick excitement at the last part.

Darius felt his jaw clench, but he kept silent.

High Chancellor Mereen raised a hand. “Captain Valkyrie. What exactly are we dealing with? You know her best. Speak.”

He met her gaze. “We haven’t talked about anything remotely like that.”

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Voxx stood and flicked his wrist at the viewing wall, projecting footage off his comtech. Darius ushering Nyx to her room and then, after a brief exchange of urgency, Nyx warping away.

Darius straightened his shoulders. “That’s my partner. We haven’t shared any confidential truths of *that* nature. There is nothing I can say outside of light jest, commands and passing words.”

“**Lies!**” Voxx snapped, his voice cutting through Darius’s words. The room erupted into pandemonium again. He heard different phrases cut through the air: “Permanent sedation...”, “Genetic lock...”, “Dissection and anatomical study...”

He watched as dozens of delegates tried accessing her file, only to be met with a blaring red exclamation mark as the dossier failed to load. Blocks, errors, redactions, no known bloodline, no genetic registry, and no origin logs.

Dr. Ekros’s signature was found under more and more redacted information. His hands trembled in their teal gloves as he stammered his defences.

Darius finally roared over the chaos, “If we don’t run her off, we can learn everything passively. Let her stay in the Apex Corps and continue to work with what you already have. The moment we retaliate, especially violently, you will lose all control, risking a free-for-all. Apex against Apexes. And as it stands we are no match for her.”

Silence echoed through the chamber as the delegates stared at him. Commander Voxx rose again, taking the opportunity to speak. “I second this. Things are stable with her, for now. Her P16 hasn’t even been conducted yet. Let Dr. Vaelith manage it; a familiar face and a place here should soothe any potential flares.”

“The subject is one of many anomalies. If given time, we can safely control it,” Dr. Ekros added, standing after Voxx took a seat.

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The delegates murmured together for a moment before a delegate from Blackroot Verge stood, her verdant green skin making her stand out sharply against her white robes. “If there are healing energies, she must be fostered and nurtured, not dissected. Or we risk losing it altogether.”

A Cryothorne delegate muttered his icy agreement. “We have the resources if we have time.”

Slow nods circled the table and Chancellor Mereen pressed a hand to her face, her frustration showing. “Commander Voxx,” she said finally, “the subject will remain under your care for now. You report directly to me. Every breath, every move. I refuse to be caught off guard again.”

“Understood,” Voxx said. The High Chancellor sounded the obsidian gong and the Council was adjourned.

Voxx didn’t hesitate and descended from the dais in a single sweep of his wings. He didn’t speak, just jerked his chin toward the yawning doors. Darius fell in step behind him, heart thudding and sweat prickling his back. Things were about to get a whole lot worse.

Chapter 22

Fane Solomon Dryst felt the pneumatic tubes tear at his skin as he rose, the long awaited last piece finally in place. The hiss of hydraulics echoed like a death knell through the reactor, metal limbs groaning as the deceptively old medical throne dragged itself upright, locking around his rotted form with surgical precision. He flinched as the long needles slid into his bones and spine, syncing him to the masterpiece he had spent decades perfecting.

He checked the exo-rig as it hissed alive and accepted the feed, a vicious cocktail of necro-acid and stabilising marrow gel, all pumping through the semi-organic tubing. The inner layer, resistant only because it was stitched from harvested Dreg hides, pulsed against his skin warm and soft. It had taken years to gather enough compatible tissues, years of hunting and painstakingly slicing and rendering.

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He flexed from his toes to his fingers, a smile creeping on his face. He turned in a flash to see Ekros rounding the corner, wide-eyed and face pale as ash. “Fane—?”

Fane turned slowly, savouring the metallic stretch of his limbs, the full corrosive power of his energy swirling around him. He gazed down at the old man, sneering, “You think you’re the smartest person in every room.” he rasped in disdain, his voice amplified through the rigs’ modulator. He strode past the small man, each step slamming into the floor like a gavel. “You think I would leave my life in your pathetic hands? You’re more naive than I thought.”

He strode to the central chamber, dragging his acid-seeded claws along the reinforced glass of the Sweetling’s tanks. Inside, the grotesque creatures shivered and twitched, malformed hideous hybrids of Dreg, Apex, and whatever else Ekros had cobbled together in his blind ambition. The Sweetling’s very skin recoiled from his presence, sending the creatures banging and scratching the far side of their tanks in a desperate effort to get away from him.

“Fane, please,” Ekros stammered behind him. “This isn’t protocol. Why don’t you calm—”

Fane spun, his heels crunching over the brittle bone fragments on the floor. He leaned down slightly, narrowing his eyes at the shaking, small man in front of him before turning back to the smallest Sweetling. “You seem to have forgotten. Exactly. Who. I. **Am.**” he said coldly, as he activated the control console. The Sweetling whimpered, its half-formed mouth gaping at him. It screamed a wet and violent sound as it was ejected from its tank, convulsing as it was sucked down into the pipework and flushed into the undercity like poison through a vein. He moved on to the second, then the third, repeating the process and unleashing the Sweetlings into the underbelly.

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Ekros was stumbling around, “What are your targets? What is your objective? If you unleash them without coordination, the AAN...” the words died on his lips as Fane looked down on him with disgust.

“The AAN will panic,” he said flatly. “They’ll send their little soldiers into the dark to be eaten. They’ll divert resources and beg for answers as they try to clean up the mess their arrogance caused.” He walked over the main console and pulled up a new schematic.

It was a carefully marked map showcasing the structural weak points in the surface of Titan. Massive. Load-bearing pylons, sub-crustal support anchors, resource tunnels that fed power directly to the Catalyst Wells. The very veins and life blood of Titan.

Ekros stood frozen behind him as he watched the stress alerts light up the screen, reactor heat spikes, and structural breach warnings, all started to flood the feed. “You...you can’t be serious.” he finally rasped. “If the Sweetlings breach those, Titan itself could collapse. The Frostline plates, the whole Nexus...millions will die.”

Fane turned slowly, the exo-rig hissing as he felt his acid flair with his temper. “Exactly.” he hissed, the acid burning his throat and lips slightly as he spoke.

“You seem to forget who I am, Ekros.” Fane said again as he turned back to the monitors punching a quick sequence of numbers in. The reactor groaned in response, the thermal shields groaning open revealing hundreds of Sweetlings. Not one specimen wasted or thrown away like Ekros has stupidly thought.

While the snively man was catering to the AAN, Fane had been tirelessly at work. He walked toward the massive glass tubes to admire his handy work in the full, harsh fluorescent light. Hundreds of Sweetlings twitched awake in their glass wombs. Towering into the dark ceiling of the reactor, these Sweetlings stood well over twenty feet, their skin shimmered and

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their spines jutted with bone and metal ridges. Not one scrap had been wasted, not one expense spared.

Alarms were going off as the chamber lights dimmed, power rerouting to the main sectors of Titan. Ekros ran to the console, systematically overriding the alarms, clearly happy to be doing something useful.

“Send word to Helion Prime.” Fane said coldly as he stretched his arms wide. His exo suit rose higher, spine unfurling from his back, acid dripping from the honed bone. “We will see how your Sweetlings fare against the Apex. And when Myth dispatches them easily, I will send my work in.”

Fane left Ekros without another word, his silence more deafening than any parting threat. He moved swiftly through the bowels of the undercity, calculating and thinking as his massive exoframe whispered and hissed. Patrols would flood the area soon, and even though he was well equipped he had no intention of being caught in the crossfire.

He came upon the Big O abruptly to find it thrumming with energy and chatter. Fane wasted no time kicking the door in with all his force and stalking into the small hovel. The laughter died immediately as the Dregs inside rose and scrambled as the acid air filled the Big O like a funeral dirge.

Fane scanned the room, his gaze sharp and venomous until he saw the one he sought. Vexal.

Already standing, Vexal met his gaze head on, unwavering. Fane saw why instantly, his skin, the clarity in his eyes, the way he stood taller than before. He had been healed. *By Myth.*

He snarled, the hate in his chest boiling over, “**Traitor.**” he hissed.

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The words hung in the air like poison and he heard Dregs scream in panic as the atmosphere thickened even more. The walls began to sag and corrode and bottles shattered from the chemical concentration. Fane moved swiftly, charging Vexal at full speed, grabbing the dreg by the throat and slamming him into the floor. Embedding him to the crumbling stone with a sickening crack, his claws twitching with restraint.

“You took what was mine.” Fane rasped, letting Vexal finally go.

Vexal choked and coughed, out of breath as he righted himself out of the floor. “I didn’t—”

That earned him another, deeper squeeze around his throat. Fane’s claws nipped at his flesh, just shy of piercing his skin but cutting off his words.

With a disgusted hiss, Fane dropped him again, turned and stalked out, the floor sizzling in his wake. He heard Vexal cough and sputter before following him obediently into the dark.

As Fane stormed back to the reactor his mind was like a raging inferno, his eyes twitching non-stop, obstructing his vision and diminishing his patience even more. He barely acknowledged Ekros scrambling aside as the little rat barely avoided being trampled at his abrupt entry. He heard some Sweetlings stir in their glass cages, mewling in fear at his return.

He felt Vexal hesitate at the entrance, eyeing the reactor with fear. Fane didn’t bother to look at him and activated the stasis clamps in the medical chamber. Energy rods surged in response, a cold metal bed rose from the floor almost vertically in the cramped area.

“Get. In.” he growled, waiting, his temper barely contained as Vexal slowly walked over. As soon as he was close enough a dozen containment arms shot out slamming into Vexal’s body, restraining him with bone-breaking force to the bed, the Dreg’s skull clattering off the surface

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metal. Cutting aside the filthy clothes, Fane exposed Vexal's new pristine flesh. His hatred threatened to choke him.

"What did she do to you **now**?" he snarled, voice dripping with contempt. "I supposed it is time to find out just how much you can take." he said with finality.

He watched with satisfaction as the stasis clamp's needles bit into Vexal's limbs and torso. He watched as his muscles corded under his pale white skin, the flawlessness of it making Fane sick to his stomach. Fane reached out, his hand trembling slightly, Vexal's leg, his fingers sinking deeply into his thigh tissue. He heard Vexal hiss and grit his teeth as Fane's grip tightened. The monstrous power of his exo-suit shattering the bone with a sickening and unrelenting crunch. Shards of bone pierced through the flesh and chunky black blood splashed the chamber floors. Vexal's screams ricocheted across the reactor like a symphony of agony.

Fane let go of the ruined leg, watching the blood pool with satisfaction. "Oh Vexal." he sighed finally, moving closer to his torso. He took a long claw and sliced into Vexal's chest, his claw parting the flesh like a knife through butter, until the boy's sternum was laid bare. Fane took his time examining his anatomy amidst the increasing beautiful screams and gasps of pain coming from his now compliant patient. He stitched him back together after what must have been hours, finally satisfied with what he found. "It seems like whatever improvement that Myth may have made, they certainly don't make you impervious."

He turned back to the control dais and released the restraints. Vexal collapsed onto the black, blood-stained floor, wheezing for breath. Fane kicked him into the direction of the main area, profane curses spilling from his lips. He stepped firmly on Vexal's other leg, stopping him from reaching the chamber door where Ekros hovered like a nervous wraith, peeking around his disgustingly bright red frames.

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“Ekros.” he spat. “Here. **Now.**”

Ekros scurried forward, eyes wide and fearful as he looked over Vexal’s mangled form.

“On your knees. Rat.” Fane barked, his voice like a thunderous boom in the confined space. Ekros flinched and began to quickly sink to his knees on the blood slicked floor, his body shaking with fear.

“Get on with it.” Fane growled, his impatience rising.

Ekros looked at Fane, tears pouring down his face as his hands shook so violently that the simple task of disrobing seemed an insurmountable challenge. Finally a mess of clothes and lab gear tumbled to the ground at the doctor’s feet, leaving him exposed and vulnerable, his age and frailty on full display.

Without warning, Fane lashed out, his large booted foot driving hard into the doctor’s chest. The breath exploded out of the weak man’s lungs in a single, agonized whoosh as he went flying backwards and crashing into the ground, landing hard besides Vexal’s prone form.

“Synergise. Now.” Fane took a menacing step towards them, his voice leaving no room for argument.

Vexal stirred with trembling limbs and his chest heaving, pained groans coming from him as he pushed himself upright. Fane watched with glee as Vexal slowly straddled the doctor's prone, trembling form and positioned himself to attempt to synergise with the old rat. The doctor screamed and thrashed beneath him but Vexal persevered with grim determination, finally pushing himself into the wailing old man.

Ekros’s back arched, a silent scream tearing from his throat as Vexal began to move as tears leaked from his eyes from the effort and pain. Time seemed to slow to a halt for Fane as he watched in a haze, the doctor's sweat and agony almost palpable on his tongue. He watched how

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the rot slowly curled around the old man's waist and legs, tendons melting like butter from the corrupted energy.

When the doctor's cries became feeble and weak, Fane abruptly hauled Vexal off by the neck, letting the Dreg collapse on the floor beside the prostrate doctor. A dark hunger stirred within Fane, the need for raw energy radiating from his body. His hands slowly shook as slightly reached down, claws clicking and scraping against the black amour of his lower exosuit as he undid the fastening.

Vexal looked up at the sound, eyes widening and Fane loved the subtle tremors that wracked the Dregs frame. Fane laughed slightly as Vexal tried to scramble away, muscles spasming in protest as Fane's claws clamped down on his shoulder, sinking into his flesh and bone. Vexal screamed, a sound of pain and terror, spurning Fane's desire to a feverish pitch. He hauled Vexal up and flipped him onto his hands and knees, one hand fisting his inky black hair at the nape of his neck, the other gripping his white hip hard enough to crack bone. He heard Vexal's breath catch as he snapped his hips forward with such a brutal force that Vexal screamed, his voice raw and enraged with the sudden, searing pain.

Fane watched as tears poured down Vexal's bruised and battered face as he lost himself in the brutal rhythm of his own pleasure. His movements became more erratic, his hips jerking and spasming against Vexal's backside as the strange energy coursing through the young Dreg's veins began to intertwine with his own acidic mutation. He gasped as the unnatural decay began to infest every cell, his fingers flexing, claws sinking deeper as he felt Vexal's essence pour out of him.

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Fane laughed with each brutal thrust, delirious with the flood of energy burning through his veins. Finally with an animalistic roar Fane released the surge of acidic decay, letting the energy pour out of his body in waves.

With a shuddering sigh, Fane rose. His grotesque exo-rig was slick with sweat and other fluids. Vexal collapsed face first onto the blood-stained floor, gasping and shaking in a fetal heap. Fane loomed over his broken form, a cruel smile forming on his lips. “You see now son.” he said, his voice dripping with self-satisfaction. “You belong to me. And not you, Myth, the AAN or Thallion Voxx himself will stop me from getting what I want.”

Chapter 23

Myth sat quietly in a dim booth at a Luminal café, her legs tucked to the side, her hands still sticky from the syrupy dessert she had bought from the vast menu. A whirlwind of thoughts ripped through her brain on repeat as she tasted the different citrus-duster spirals, trying to decipher the flavor to distract herself. The lights buzzed softly above her; her comtech sat silently beside her amidst the empty snack wrappers, and she resisted the urge to glance at either again.

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She rolled her eyes and checked again, just to be sure, but still nothing. Before she flicked the screen away, a tiny emergency notification in the corner caught her eye. Her heart stuttered as she opened it to see that someone had tried to ping her seven different times. She was on her feet before she even realised, one thought on her mind: *Vexal*.

In a blink, she warped straight there only to be slapped in the face by the destroyed Big O. Charred, acidic wreckage was everywhere everywhere she looked. Someone was crying deeper inside, but it was eerily quiet. She stepped through the ruins slowly, her boots crackling against the shattered glass, her mind whirling. Acid had eaten through walls, tables, even the floor itself in places. Muted groans echoed from deeper inside, and her hands flew up instinctively. Energy surged through her palms as she swept them outward, light and time coalescing in waves that began to pull the wreckage back together. Twisted girders straightened, busted vents sealed, most of the worst acidic areas healed. She mended what she could, breathing deeply as the air cleared and she pushed deeper. She found Lyra, her body scorched raw, her cloak melted into the shredded bedding she lay on, her breath ragged and shallow. Myth dropped to her knees, the world tilting around her. “No. No, no, no,” she whispered as she ran her hands over Lyra's chest and side, energy pouring out of her in gold and violet threads, healing the charred flesh.

Lyra jolted with a strangled gasp and her body arched sharply before collapsing again, trembling, her eyes fluttering wildly. She grabbed Myth by the shoulders, her fingers twitching. “Fane took Vexal,” Lyra gasped, the panic rising in her voice.

A cold stab of guilt pierced Myth's heart and settled in her gut. She stood up slowly, feeling the energy buzzing through her fingertips.

“Where did they go?” she asked, her voice almost cracking.

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Lyra shook her head, her eyes glassy. “I have no idea. It all happened so fast, and Dryst’s not really somebody you can just... follow,” she sighed heavily. “The O is wrecked, and we gotta get it back together and then figure out what the wreck to do.”

Myth nodded solemnly. Her pulse was erratic, and she struggled to keep calm. She turned and looked at the remaining destruction. The Big O used to be almost a sanctuary, but now it was in ruins. Acid burns along the walls, shattered fixtures, and buckled beams. The smell alone made her stomach clench.

She didn’t speak; she didn’t trust her voice not to shake. She picked up where she had left off, easing the structure back from the brink of collapse. The floor cracked and groaned and the ceiling screeched violently as they reformed. She poured her energy into fortifying the walls, resealing pipes, and cooling hotspots. Layer by layer, the Big O was standing solid once again.

Myth collapsed into a nearby chair, exhausted but alert, examining her handiwork. She had been careful with her energy, knowing that whatever happened, she would need some whenever Vexal returned. If he returned.

Lyra had been up the moment she was able to stand. She had a slight limp, but she was relentless. Her short violet hair was tied back tightly, blood still crusted along one temple as she barked orders. She moved through the restored Big O quickly, taking count, checking the outside perimeter for weaknesses, calling in what few scouts they could muster.

Myth wanted to help, wanted to go search for Vexal. But she couldn’t go out like that anymore, too many eyes would notice her, too many chances someone might recognise her. And she couldn’t help the thought that if she left, she would miss something again. So she sat, watching and feeling useless. So much had changed in her short time away from the O; she didn’t know who or where anyone was anymore. Where anything belonged, it was all new. She

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was trying to think of what supplies or tasks she might be helpful with when the front door slammed open so hard it shook the heavy ceiling lock as it clanged open.

Weapons were drawn before Myth could even register the blur in the snowstorm. A figure crawled in, white with frost, limbs dragging, soaked in black blood that steamed on contact with the warm floor. It collapsed with a sickening crunch, face-first into the floor.

“**Vexal!**” Lyra screamed.

Myth didn’t even feel herself moving, her knees cold on the melting snow, already reaching out to turn him over with trembling hands.

The overwhelming smell of acid, smoke, and blood hit her first. She caught a flash of ribs, the skin torn away surgically. His entire right side was slack, both his legs shattered with the skin split open.

Myth fought the rising bile in her throat as Lyra bolted the door again, shouting over the din for more heat-types. Snow was pouring down sideways now, the cold air slicing through all the cracks in the walls like icy blades. Cryothorne snow, even though it wasn’t during the winter cycle, wasn’t uncommon in the Undercity, but she worried it was a harbinger of a much larger problem.

Korric stomped up abruptly. “I’m taking first watch.”

Lyra nodded and helped Myth gently lift Vexal. Lyra led the way, bringing her deep into what seemed to be his own personal quarters. A low, narrow cot tucked between cracked monitors and half-built tech. Paper sheets and old datapads littered every surface. As they laid Vexal gently on his cot, her heart almost thudded to a stop in her chest. He looked like a corpse, the way his jaw hung unhinged.

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Myth knelt beside the low bed, reaching out with trembling fingers. His skin was burning cold against her hands. “Vexal?” she whispered, tears slipping down her cheeks. “I’ll fix this. I can fix this...”

His good eye flew open, bloodied and glassy. He flinched away. “No... you...” he croaked, his words muddled by his broken jaw. His eyelids fluttered closed as he slipped back into unconsciousness, his body shuddering violently.

She knew he was always worried she would run out of energy, but she couldn’t leave him like this. He would certainly die if something drastic wasn’t done.

Lyra’s hand landed gently on her shoulder. “Please,” Lyra whispered, “hurry and help him. Just... be gentle.”

Myth nodded silently as she placed both hands over his chest, releasing her energy gently into him. It felt like diving into an inferno, the acidic resonance shaking her to her core. The normal comforting fire of his Rot was a swirl of pain and horror. She pushed on, feeling his ribs and chest cavity inflate back to their original form. His jaw clenched with a sickening pop, and his legs shook slightly as the bones slowly reformed.

She pushed as hard as she dared, her eyes blurring around the edges, her vision tilting from the effort. After a long moment, she collapsed backward, caught only by Lyra’s quick arms. She steadied herself quickly as Lyra surged forward with a bright orange medical kit. She worked swiftly, dabbing his skin with salve, the burns still raw and slightly blistered from how deep they had been.

Myth went and leaned against the back wall, dizzy with exhaustion and guilt. She felt the cold seep in and walked swiftly back to the entrance of the Big O. Korric still stood watch by the front door, an unmoving dark sentry, his face grim as frost dusted his shoulders heavily.

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“Vexal’s alive,” she said when she was close enough. “I did everything I could.”

Korric nodded, his face stoic. “You shouldn’t blame yourself.”

“Yeah... okay,” she said, her voice barely over a whisper. She pulled out her comtech, a flash of worry lancing through her as it took longer than usual to load. Much longer. Korric looked over her shoulder with a deep furrow in his brow as warnings flashed from the top of the screen.

A roll of messages and missed pings started to appear down the screen. Dozens from Darius, Commander Voxx, even Eira Solaris, along with two official summons from the AAN. She looked at Korric; his face was drawn tightly.

“I’ll let them know,” he said. Myth nodded and tried to gather her energy, but her body staggered sideways. Korric caught her by her elbow. “You look drained. Don’t push it.”

Myth nodded and focused again, pressing her palms together and finally mustering enough energy to warp back into her room.

Nyx was hit immediately by a blaring wall of red. Sirens and alerts were going off in tandem, her comtech flickering with erratic words and scrambled screens.

She staggered a bit, blood rushing through her veins as she bolted into the main hallway to find everything in chaos. Echelons ran around executing orders, Apexes bolted past her in partial gear, and the announcement systems blared emergency bulletins loudly overhead.

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She tapped her comtech again and it stuttered and jumped, screens slurring across her wrist like a seizure. Darius's ID ping kept trying to load, but failed each time. She barely made it five steps forward before someone grabbed her arm.

"Dock B24!" a red-haired aide shouted over the din. "Captain Valkyrie's been looking for you!"

She nodded at the aide and warped mid-step, reappearing in a whoosh of displaced air on the transport dock, her boots hitting the metal hard. The dock was full of smoke, electrical discharge, and pure adrenaline. Rows of transports hissed and roared as they loaded members of the elite Black Operations Division. Strong enforcers from the Tech Enforcement Bureau, brought out only to strong-arm people into submission.

The moment Darius rounded the corner, the fury in his eyes hit her like a slap across the face.

"Where the hell were you?" he snapped, charging in her direction.

She pulled up her comtech at him, its screen flickering worse and worse, as an explanation.

His expression shifted instantly. "We have multiple Level Ten breaches. Four districts have been compromised in total. Nova-tier Dregs are rampant in the infrastructure with unknown mutations and no registry matches. If we can't contain them..." He gestured vaguely around him. "The death toll will be unimaginable. Millions of people will die."

Her blood ran cold in her veins; she knew who it was immediately. The only person who would even have the power capable of pulling off such a thing.

Fane Dryst.

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She wanted to slap herself for not trying to get more information from Korric about him before she left. She had felt his acidic energy so strongly within Vexal; she knew Vexal had just seen him. Maybe Vexal had tried to stop him? That's why...

Her skin prickled, heat flooding her eyes, anger gripping her spine. Darius studied her for half a second before barking, "Let's gear up."

Across the bay, Apexes were gathering fast in full mobilisation wear. Squad after squad fell into order with Commander Voxx at the centre. Fully suited in his glowing exosuit, his wings were deployed rigidly behind him. He was giving orders to a triage unit next to General King, his solar emblem glowing like a molten sun in his chest.

Nyx quickly sprinted to the gear wall and retrieved two regulator harnesses, sliding one firmly around her body, the energy seals pulsing alive and venting fresh pressure against her skin, creating a strong protective barrier.

She ran back and shoved one at Darius. "You are going to need these," she said. Darius gave her a look before nodding and slipping into his own harness. She stalked quickly to their transport, bracing for take-off. As soon as they were strapped in, they rocketed into the red and black sky. Darius turned to her, quickly pulling up a console. "I need you to warp us in, here." His finger hovered over a heavily red sector decorated with numerous high-level security beacons. "This is Sector Zero," he explained. "It's directly below the Undercity and is, essentially, the lifeblood of Titan."

She leaned in, studying the maze, noting that not only did Sector Zero connect the primary reactors, but it also had direct lines to the Catalyst Wells and atmospheric regulators.

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Darius pointed again. “These are our primary targets to close off. If we lose one, we lose at least half a district. Structural damage has to be top priority and kept to an absolute minimum.”

Nyx nodded, her ears buzzing loudly, her body tense. “Let’s do this!” she said. Darius nodded and tapped the console a few more times before energising his gauntlet. He gave the signal to the main comm and Nyx placed a hand on his shoulder. She focused on the map one last time before closing her eyes, landing them silently in the acidic depths of Sector Zero.

Only a few dim orange service lights blinked in the overhead pipes, black shadows falling in broken lattices across the massive industrial cathedral. Darius’s body lit the corridor like a human flare, his Magma core shining in rich molten hues. Acid traces still burned faintly across the shields, and she marvelled that the interior held up the way it did. The location ping had brought them just across from Catalyst Well Three, and the first Dreg had almost beaten them to it. It was a huge, lurching body that slithered and limped across the pipework, its skin an eerie patchwork hide. The moment it saw them, it growled before turning and running.

“Don’t let it reach the Well!” Darius barked, already taking off like a rocket after it. Nyx surged forward, shaping dark spikes from the ground to herd the thing toward a different branch. But it was fast and slimy, evading their blasts with desperate dexterity.

They burst into the main chamber, Catalyst Well Three pulsing in the far back with erratic energy, casting them in a wash of pale blue light.

The creature wailed and charged for the Well, ripping apart pipes and beams as it launched itself towards the light. Darius threw himself between the Dreg and the Well, releasing a roaring beam of blue-orange fire. The immediate heat was intense, burning away the acid and singeing their protective shields.

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The Dreg screamed in pain, its arms stretching and flailing wildly, catching her across the ribs in a crushing acidic grip.

A sharp pang of rage lanced through her skull as she screamed, unleashing an obliterating dark streak of energy straight through its limb, disintegrating it on contact. The Dreg screamed as she pressed her energy further, pinning it and pulling it apart into a pile of disintegrating matter.

They had no time to celebrate as the ceiling above them tore open. She barely dodged the falling Dreg that was clearly looking for its companion. It was much larger than the one she had just dispatched, and it was dripping acid like blood, cracking the floor beneath it.

It was engaged in a brutal clash of energies against Eira and King. Acid had burned across King's chestplate, and Eira's left shoulder was blackened and sizzling. They had clearly fought hard, but the cramped space was restraining their ability to fully use their energy.

Nyx felt another lance through her skull as she charged straight into the Dreg's oversized maw, letting it swallow her whole. For a moment, it was nothing but pure acidic agony. Her body bathed in corrosive acid, Fane's energy swirling like a maelstrom inside the Dreg. It made her sick to her stomach, and the pain sent her energy spiking. Igniting from within, her energy tore through the Dreg, disintegrating it from the inside out, erupting violently in an acidic volcano of muscle, bone, and bile.

Her knees hit the ground, her mind already scrambling to fix the pipes from the acid. Eira came in alongside her, icing down what she could, the Well behind them stabilising.

King barked into his comtech, his voice sharp and out of breath, "T.E.B., secure site! We are going for the next Well!" He turned to Nyx and Darius, his voice cutting through the din. "Well Five's is being ripped through its core. If it hits the core siphon, we will lose atmospheric containment for the entire district."

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“I can warp us,” Nyx said, stepping forward.

The General nodded without hesitation. “Do it.”

“Hold on to each other,” she said, clenching her fist, her energy roaring through her veins, and then they vanished.

They landed roughly in a cloud of acrid smoke. Well Five’s section was in way worse condition than Three’s had been. The pipes shuddered under their boots as acid chewed through the metal walkway. Nyx reacted instantly, extending a dome of crackling energy around them to hold the air at bay.

The Dreg was chewing through the Well’s casing, its limbs crawling over the Well’s thick support spine. It had chewed through one of the anchors already and was working on the other three with its acid-dripping claws, making the massive conduit of power spew sparks of energy wildly into the air.

Darius and King rushed in first, bodies glowing brightly in the dim light. King grabbed one of the creature’s legs, dragging it backward by sheer strength while Darius launched himself at a limb that was scratching at the anchor, searing Magma across its tendons as he helped King drag it off the Well. Acid sprayed everywhere, sizzling through their suits and eating down to the very skin.

The Dreg shrieked, mutating before their very eyes from the massive amount of raw energy it had absorbed. Its body twisted, exploding through the Undercity ceiling, crashing into the levels above before being dragged back by Darius and King, their bodies swelling from the sheer physical effort.

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Alarms wailed down from above as distant voices screamed in terror, the infrastructure twisting and melting. Eira rushed in, icing everything in her path, trying to stop the corrosive acid and bring some stability to the gaping ceiling, sealing it off in a thick wall of ice.

Nyx turned to the Well as a shock of energy flew toward her in a bright blue arc. Pain lanced through her skull and she staggered. Voices screamed at her from all directions. Darius, King, Eira, their voices overlapping Vexal's and Lyra's. White flashed behind her eyes; the Big O flashed through her mind, then dying in someone's arms. Her mind reeled, the flood of thoughts and images making her feel like she was looking into another timeline. Flashes of another life split through her: she was a child, laughing alongside a blonde boy in a beautiful garden.

She screamed from the pain, power surging through her arms at the Dreg. The monster convulsed and roared in pain, bursting into a bloody acid rain. It parted into three smaller forms, each screaming and rushing towards the Well.

Darius reacted fast, Magma pulsing out of his palms in a blaze of brilliant orange-blue. He closed in on one, his palms frying its body into black dust and bones.

Eira moved with lightning speed, switching from ice to fire, sending ice-hot shockwaves over the second Dreg, freezing it solid before it shattered in a small explosion of frost and ice.

The General was left with the largest one, its body moving sluggishly from already taking several major hits.

"Nyx! Boost!" King roared at her.

She turned, raising her hands at him, pouring her energy into him, her mind struggling to form a coherent thought.

King ignited like a miniature sun from the flood of energy, his skin turning fluorescent, his power radiating from him. With a yell, he drew both hands into a colossal column of focused

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Solar light nearly twice his size. He cleaved through the last monster with surgical precision, melting the monster into the beam beneath it.

The chamber lurched, a violent tilt to the side. Well Five was failing and failing fast. The T.E.B. scrambled in, trying to reach the control panels, but shockwaves from the breached Well threw them back against the walls.

“What do we do?” King shouted into his cometech.

A voice crackled through their comtechs, flickering wildly, making the words hard to hear. “We... rig a containment gate,” a young Echelon tech shouted, his voice trembling. “But... too wide... a full energy... harness... hold.”

“We don’t have one,” Darius snarled, already forming a molten shield to protect them from the erratic energy flashes. King shoved himself behind it and started walking towards the Well. “Get to the Well. We will place what we can.” Eira slid to the back of the tunnel, grabbing the containment harnesses from an Echelon tech. Nyx took one from her and they both squeezed in behind Darius and King, pushing forward to the Well.

The closer they got, the more gravity condensed around them, the weight of the planet pressing down on them. Nyx felt her nose begin to bleed and saw that Eira’s ears were dripping blood, while Darius and King both had significant nosebleeds.

The heat was so intense at the base of the Well that the Magma wall began to melt, so Darius let it burn down enough to let them work.

The breaches were wide and irregular; the harness, not having any surface to attach to, couldn’t span the entire Well.

Eira looked to King helplessly, blood sputtering from her lips.